human rights throughout Europe and the world.

Many self-styled rationalists tend to argue that Napoleon should have made it his life's mission to achieve the first goal – securing French domination in Europe. But why? Remember that for Clausewitz rationality means alignment. A tactical manoeuvre is rational if, and only if, it is aligned with some higher strategic goal, which should in turn be aligned with an even higher political goal. But where does this chain of goals ultimately start? How can we determine the ultimate goal that justifies all the strategic sub-goals and tactical steps derived from it? Such an ultimate goal by definition cannot be aligned with anything higher than itself, because there is nothing higher. What then makes it rational to place France at the top of the goal hierarchy, rather than Napoleon's family, Napoleon's fame, Napoleon's soul or universal human rights? Clausewitz provides no answer.

One might argue that goal number 4 – securing the redemption of his everlasting soul – cannot be a serious candidate for an ultimate rational goal, because it is based on a belief in mythology. But the same argument can be levelled at all the other goals. Everlasting souls are an intersubjective invention that exists only in people's minds, and exactly the same is true of nations and human rights. Why should Napoleon care about the mythical France any more than about his mythical soul?

Indeed, for most of his youth, Napoleon didn't even consider himself French. He was born Napoleone di Buonaparte on Corsica, to a family of Italian emigrants. For five hundred years Corsica was ruled by the Italian city-state of Genoa, where many of Napoleone's ancestors lived. It was only in 1768 – a year before Napoleone's birth – that Genoa ceded the island to France. Corsican nationalists resisted being handed over to France and rose in rebellion. Only after their defeat in 1770 did Corsica formally become a French province. Many Corsicans continued to resent the French takeover, but the di Buonaparte family swore allegiance to the French king and sent Napoleone to military school in mainland France.[29]

At school, Napoleone had to endure a good deal of bullying from his classmates for his Corsican nationalism and his poor command of the French language.[30] His mother tongues were Corsican and Italian, and although he gradually became fluent in French, he retained throughout his life a Corsican accent and an inability to spell French correctly.[31]